# John Cage's Fourth Construction: An Imaginary Landscape

Thad Anderson

A significant yet puzzling premiere of a John Cage work took place in San Francisco, California, on May 7, 1942. This event occurred close to the culmination of Cage's extensive work developing the early American percussion ensemble. On the evening of its premiere, this work was titled "Fourth Construction." Soon after its debut, however, this composition was retitled "Imaginary Landscape No. 2," which joined two additional pieces within that series. "Imaginary Landscape No. 1," "No. 2," and "No. 3" represent Cage's early experimentation using electronic devices and sliding tones in musical compositions.

A similar counterpart to this group of works is Cage's "Construction" series (the collection of pieces to which "Imaginary Landscape No. 2" was originally assigned). Composed during the same time period, "First," "Second," and "Third Construction" epitomize Cage's experimentation with timbre, rhythm, and formal structure. The "Constructions" have become a central component of the percussion ensemble repertoire, and many admirers of these pieces wish Cage had further explored this compositional format.

Because of the perceived "split personality" of the "Fourth Construction" ("Construction" or "Imaginary Landscape"?), there are many unanswered questions surrounding academic and performance aspects of this work. An examination of the mysterious change of title and the "curious numbering" of the "Imaginary Landscape" series will provide further insight into Cage's so-called "Fourth Construction."

## EARLY INFLUENCES: EMERGENCE OF THE PERCUSSION ENSEMBLE

The Bennington School of Dance once hosted an innovative concert on the campus of Mills College in Oakland, California. This performance did not feature dancers, but rather musicians playing on clay pots, chunks of metal, and blocks of wood. This unique concert was presented by John Cage and his percussion group from the Cornish School in Seattle, Washington. They performed music that was specifically written for them by such West Coast composers as Lou Harrison, Johanna Beyer, Henry Cowell, William Russell, and Cage himself. John Cage created this moment in musical history by initiating and inventing his own musical outlet, the percussion ensemble, which scarcely existed at the time. It is now understood that this ensemble served an important role in the development of Cage's early compositions, including those of both the "Imaginary Landscape" and "Construction" series.

Many factors are introduced when significant developments are made in establishing an entirely new genre and outlet for compositional production. This was certainly the case during the first third of the twentieth century. In 1933, Henry Cowell began to publish the first exclusive percussion ensemble music through his *New Music Quarterly* collection. Cowell explains, "Up to this year, in my experience as a music publisher, I have never been offered any work for percussion instruments alone. This season I have been offered fifteen."[1] Significant developments, such as *klangfarben*, futurism, machine music, and the outgrowth of chamber music involving the ever-widening use of percussion, began to take place, which led to the emergence of the percussion ensemble and to Cage's later experimentation and developments with the genre.

Cowell's interest in the percussion ensemble couldn't have come at a better time. During this same period, Cowell had begun working with two young and innovative students — Lou Harrison and John Cage. Both took courses and private lessons with Cowell and were heavily influenced by his knowledge of this new compositional outlet. "Although

both [Harrison and Cage] were aware of recent European and American music for percussion ensemble, the impact of Cowell's teaching was profound."[2] Even Cage noted, "Henry Cowell was for many years the 'open sesame' for new music in America."[3] Through Cowell, Cage was introduced to many important factors that later became central to his involvement with percussion. These include found instruments, the string piano, formal structure, dance music, and sliding tones.

With encouragement from Cowell, Cage discovered the percussion ensemble, and in 1934, after concluding studies with Cowell in New York, Cage returned to the West Coast where he proceeded to compose his own works for the genre. Later, through a written correspondence, Cowell advised Cage that the future of music relies on the "perfection" of percussion instruments and sliding tones. He also suggested that Cage develop and discover original and practical instruments and to create a situation where one performer could play multiple instruments.[4]

Cage took these bits of advice and flourished. Not only did he establish his own percussion ensemble for experimentation and performing, but he also set out to further advance the available percussion ensemble repertoire by composing his own works. This group of ten pieces, written between 1935 and 1943, encompass some of the most influential and vital notes ever written for the genre. Integral to this collection are Cage's "Construction" and "Imaginary Landscape" series. Together, they represent nearly 60 percent of his compositional output from this early phase of his career.

Through Lou Harrison and the growing relationship between percussion and dance music in the late 1930s, John Cage was employed as an accompanist at the Cornish School in Seattle, Washington. Shortly after arriving, Cage set out to initiate his own percussion ensemble. The influence behind establishing his own performing group surely came from Henry Cowell. In a March 23, 1937 letter to Cage, Cowell explained, "I was pleased to hear that you are interested in percussion developments. I was just on the point of trying to form a sort of symphonic percussion ensemble in San Francisco and another in New York before my arrest."[5]

Not far after their initial rehearsal, the ensemble presented its first concert on December 9, 1938. Within the next year, two additional performances were given, and by this time the group had already established themselves as the John Cage Percussion Players. Cage now had a performing outlet for this developing musical genre. To further establish his involvement, Cage contributed two works in 1939 that set a new tone for his compositional style: "Imaginary Landscape No. 1" and "First Construction (In Metal)."

By the time the Cage Percussion Players were fully established in 1939, Cage had only composed two works for percussion ensemble ("Quartet" and "Trio"). If Cage was truly going to advocate for the advancement of music exclusively for percussion instruments, he needed to support the cause as one of the genre's leading composers — not just a producer of concerts. This became his primary task as a composer from 1939 to 1943. James Pritchett explains, "The success of his percussion ensemble concerts, the response from other composers such as Lou Harrison, and his emergence as a primary exponent of all-percussion music led Cage to compose a number of larger works for percussion ensembles of various sorts during the period 1939–42."[6]

Within this span of time, Cage composed around ten percussion ensemble works that are now published and have become a foundational part of the repertoire. At the center of this portfolio of works are two groups of pieces: the "Construction" and "Imaginary Landscape" series.

## THE SO-CALLED "FOURTH CONSTRUCTION"

In an early 1980s interview with Stuart Smith, Cage explains, "I remain a percussion composer whether I wrote for percussion instruments or not. That is, my work is never based, structurally or as an instance of process, on frequency but rather on duration considerations."[7] Even so, many wish that Cage would have continued composing additional works for both the "Construction" and "Imaginary Landscape" series. There remains one composition within these series that has yet to be examined. It is one that perhaps fits the mold of both series (having a "split-personality," if you will), and by comparing it with the elements of the two series, one discovers its proper placement.

Due to some of Cage's personal uncertainties during this time, for the researcher, there is a great possibility for error or confusion regarding the matter. For example, David Revill, a musicologist and well-known Cage scholar, included the following sentence in his biography on Cage: "There is a mention in 1942 of a fourth 'Construction,' which may never have been finished."[8] On the other hand, musicologist Leta Miller describes a performance of a completed work in her article *The Art of Noise*: "Harrison not only recalls blowing a huge conch shell during Cage's piece, but also remembers assembling for its performance an instrument comprised of a large spring attached to a phonograph pickup... Cage wrote 'Fourth Construction' — later retitled 'March (Imaginary Landscape No. 2)' — in Chicago in April 1942 and dedicated it to Harrison."[9] This type of contradiction has left many performers and percussionists without any knowledge of a supposed "Fourth Construction."

For purposes of clarity, from here on, the author will refer to the "Fourth Construction" as "Imaginary Landscape No. 2," which is its official published title. "Imaginary Landscape No. 2" was composed in 1942 while Cage was in Chicago. He had access to a radio studio while there and composed a few works with the use of that equipment (including original music for the radio play *The City Wears a Slouch Hat*). Unlike "Imaginary Landscape No.1" and "No. 3," "No. 2" does not contain sliding tones. In fact, the only use of a pho-

nograph in the work is through the use of a radio aerial coil. This instrument is termed "an amplified coil of wire" in the score. With an older phonograph pickup arm, it was possible to connect this coil to the cartridge. When this is accomplished, the cartridge was used like a microphone or pickup to amplify the vibrating coil. The performer strikes, rubs, and scraps the coil to create various sound effects. Additional electronic devices include two buzzers that are sustained at varied lengths throughout the work.

Joining this group of electronic sounds is "a selection of the instruments used in the 'Third Construction.'"[10] As will be examined later, similarities to "Third Construction" are many. Some of these include groups of five tin cans, a conch shell, a ratchet, and a lion's roar. A bass drum is also employed, and the performer is asked to play on both the rim and the membrane. Three players are dedicated performers to the groups of tin cans. Unlike any of the other five works presented in this article, "Imaginary Landscape No. 2" contains two written cadenzas for one of the tin-can performers. These spotlight moments offer clarity to an otherwise chaotic piece.

Art Lange offers the following about the work: "'Imaginary Landscape No. 2' can be a frightening experience, chaotic and violent. There is an almost palpable tension in the seemingly non-synchronous percussion parts (though these are actually plotted along mathematical lines). The trumpeting conch horn and rhythmic urgency suggests the ritual frenzy of 'Le Sacre du Printemps,' though the huge bomb-like explosions take this to a higher, more horrific level of sacrifice."

As a whole, "Imaginary Landscape No. 2" sounds less "electronic" than "No. 1" and "No. 3." This is primarily due to the absence of the sliding tones created with the turntable and frequency-test-tone records.

From a structural standpoint, the majority of "Imaginary Landscape No. 2" uses a micro-macrocosmic format similar to that of other works in both series. The composition's general rhythmic structure is 3 + 4 + 2 + 3 + 5, which creates 17 bar units. "The opening section (three 17-measure units) begins with an almost frightening polyrhythmically dense clamor."[11]

Like in previous works that utilize this type of format, each of these three opening 17-measure units are broken down into phrases that match the rhythmic structure sequence (3 + 4 + 2 + 3 + 5). The second unit consists entirely of material for the solo tin-can cadenza (rehearsal letters C through F in the score). The third section is tutti between all five players and consists of samples of material originally heard in the first unit. This section is soft and offers an important contrast to the cacophony of the opening section.

Continuing with macrocosmic structure, this segment consists of two 17-measure units. The opening statement returns once again for the fourth section (three 17-measure units). This transitions to the final section (letter L in the score), which abandons the macrostructure. This last section, likely a coda of sorts, is only 48 bars long (rather than the expected 85). Harkening back to earlier works, this type of departure from the micro-macrocosmic structure at the end of the work is also seen in the first two "Constructions."

As mentioned in the introduction, "Imaginary Landscape No. 2" was premiered as "Fourth Construction" on Thursday, May 7, 1942, at the Holloway Playhouse in San Francisco, California (see Figure 2). This particular date is quite important because it exposes an important flaw in the numbering within the "Imaginary Landscape" series. As seen in Figure 1, there was an original "Imaginary Landscape No. 2" that was first composed and performed in 1940, two years prior to the currently published work with the same title. There is a reason for this, as Cage explains: "I admit I've been inclined as others have been inclined to get rid of bad pieces, you know, and there are some that are definitely very poor. There's an amusing point here. You have heard about the business of the 'Imaginary Landscape' and the 'Marches,' and there is one 'Imaginary Landscape' that I decided was so bad that it should simply be forgotten, and that's brought about some curious numbering."[12] Thus, the original work was entirely removed from his catalogue and it has never been seen, performed, or heard again. (See Figure 1.)

"Fourth Construction" once existed. Two reviews appeared in San Francisco-based publications the day after the premiere (See Figure 2). Marjory Fisher had this to say about the work in *The San Francisco News*: "John Cage's 'Fourth Construction' was scored for tin cans played with xylophone hammers. An electric buzzer and other strange items still unidentified, added their voices to the sounds of the cans."[13]

Alfred Frankenstein of the *San Francisco Chronicle* was less than satisfied with

***Figure 1:*** *Compositional and premiere performance timeline for the "Construction" and "Imaginary Landscape" series.*

| Composition | Composed | Premiered |
|---|---|---|
| 1. "Imaginary Landscape No. 1" | Spring 1939 | March, 24, 1939 |
| 2. "First Construction (In Metal)" | November 1939 | December, 9, 1939 |
| 3. "Second Construction" | January 1940 | February 14, 1940 |
| 4. "Imaginary Landscape No. 2"<br>*original work later withdrawn | 1940 | May 7, 1940 |
| 5. "Third Construction" | April 1941 | May 14, 1941 |
| 6. "Imaginary Landscape No. 3" | February 1942 | March 1, 1942 |
| 7. "Imaginary Landscape No. 2 (March No. 1)"<br>*originally titled "Fourth Construction" | April 1942 | May 7, 1942 |

the work: "Some of the most unorthodox of Harrison's instruments are among his best. Brake drums from junked automobiles, for instance, make marvelous tuned gongs…. But there is almost a touch of burlesque about a piece like John Cage's 'Fourth Construction,' which was played last night, and which calls for an orchestra made up very largely of half-gallon cans. Almost anything goes if it makes an interesting plink, plunk or thud, but sometimes the lack of melodic interest gets on your nerves."[14]

Referring back to Figure 1 and also to Figure 3, it is important to note the compositional dates for both "Imaginary Landscape No. 3" (February 1942) and "Imaginary Landscape No. 2" (April 1942). Consequently, "Imaginary Landscape No. 3" was composed and premiered months prior to the current existence of "Imaginary Landscape No. 2." Through deductive reasoning one can easily understand how this "curious numbering" came about. Apparently, Cage composed a third "Imaginary Landscape" in February of 1942, which was soon followed up by a fourth "Construction" in April of 1942. After the fourth "Construction" was premiered in May of that year, Cage decided to use the work as an excuse to toss the original "Imaginary Landscape No. 2" (circa 1940) and replace it with another work — the alleged "Fourth Construction." To further confuse the situation, as Cage alludes above ("the business of the 'Imaginary Landscape' and the 'Marches'"), "Imaginary Landscape No. 2" has a second title of "March No. 1." Demonstrated in Figure 3, showing the cover of this work, the fact becomes apparent that this composition has, or has had, three different titles: "Fourth Construction," "Imaginary Landscape No. 2," and "March No. 1." (See Figure 3.)

With that said, did Cage compose this work with intentions of it joining the "Construction" or "Imaginary Landscape" group of works? What characteristics does it contain? Has the title change and shift between series affected its performance value? Further examination of both collections helps to identify the proper placement of "Imaginary Landscape No. 2."

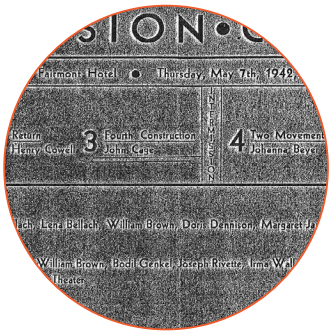
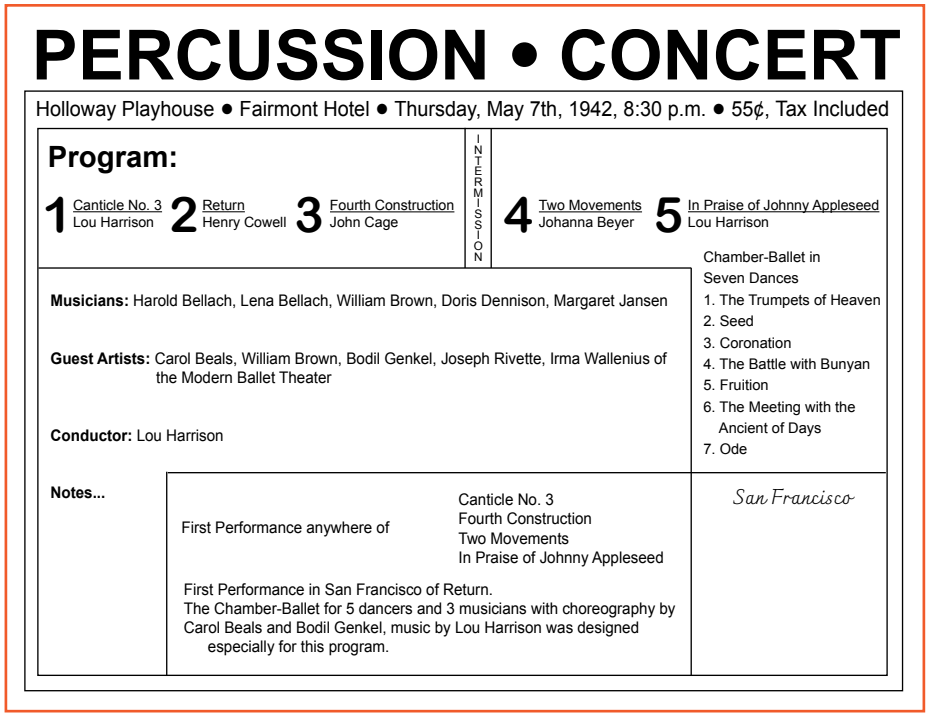



***Figure 2:*** *Concert program listing Cage's "Fourth Construction."*



PERCUSSION • CONCERT

Holloway Playhouse • Fairmont Hotel • Thursday, May 7th, 1942, 8:30 p.m. • 55¢, Tax Included

**Program:**

1 Canticle No. 3 — Lou Harrison
2 Return — Henry Cowell
3 Fourth Construction — John Cage
INTERMISSION
4 Two Movements — Johanna Beyer
5 In Praise of Johnny Appleseed — Lou Harrison

Chamber-Ballet in Seven Dances
1. The Trumpets of Heaven
2. Seed
3. Coronation
4. The Battle with Bunyan
5. Fruition
6. The Meeting with the Ancient of Days
7. Ode

**Musicians:** Harold Bellach, Lena Bellach, William Brown, Doris Dennison, Margaret Jansen

**Guest Artists:** Carol Beals, William Brown, Bodil Genkel, Joseph Rivette, Irma Wallenius of the Modern Ballet Theater

**Conductor:** Lou Harrison

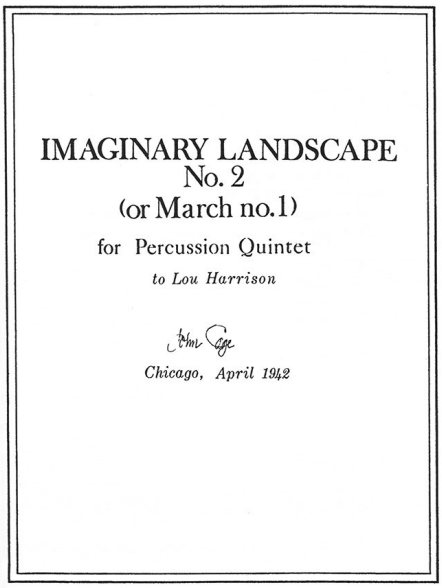
**Notes...**

First Performance anywhere of
Canticle No. 3
Fourth Construction
Two Movements
In Praise of Johnny Appleseed

First Performance in San Francisco of Return.
The Chamber-Ballet for 5 dancers and 3 musicians with choreography by Carol Beals and Bodil Genkel, music by Lou Harrison was designed especially for this program.

San Francisco

***Figure 3:*** *Cover page for "Imaginary Landscape No. 2."*



IMAGINARY LANDSCAPE
No. 2
(or March no. 1)
for Percussion Quintet
*to Lou Harrison*

John Cage
*Chicago, April 1942*

When examining the works of both the "Construction" and "Imaginary Landscape" series in the previous sections, it becomes apparent that four key elements help to designate each composition. Within those elements are defining characteristics that provide tools for analysis and juxtaposition. These are as follows:

**1. Timbre**
- Metal
- Wood
- Membrane
- Electronic devices
- Sliding tones

**2. Rhythm**
- Polyrhythms
- Complex rhythmic groupings
- Grupettos across the barline
- Rhythmic cadences

**3. Structure**
- Rhythmic structure
- Micro-macrocosmic rhythmic structure
- Fugue-like material

**4. Instruments**

- Traditional orchestral
- Found objects
- Electronic devices
- Ethnic/Eastern influence
- String piano

The timbral nature of "Imaginary Landscape No. 2" meets most, if not all, characteristics associated with the works of the "Construction" series. Within these three compositions, there is a varied texture and color that is demonstrated as the works progress. "First Construction" is rich with metallic sounds, while "Second Construction" is more functional and traditional. "Third Construction" provides the greatest timbral possibilities and, in many ways, "Imaginary Landscape No. 2" (or perhaps the fourth "Construction" in this case) can be viewed as the next progression in Cage's experimentation with sounds and texture combinations. Like "Third Construction," "Imaginary Landscape No. 2" heavily relies on the tin can. In fact, two performers are dedicated tin-can players throughout the entire work. The use of the conch shell also ties these two works closely together.

"Imaginary Landscape No. 2" represents the most rhythmically dense of these six compositions. All four rhythmic characteristics can be found throughout — so much so that it almost creates a new and unique trait of densely layered rhythms. As previously mentioned, the rhythmic structure of "Imaginary Landscape No. 2" is not unlike that of "Second Construction" or even "Imaginary Landscape No. 3." The only work of the six discussed in these pages that does not use micro-macrocosmic structure is "Imaginary Landscape No. 1." Perhaps this also makes "Imaginary Landscape No. 2" a bit more "Construction"-like.

From a performance standpoint, the "Imaginary Landscape" series is also severely underrepresented when compared to its counterpart. Unfortunately, it is not possible to accurately trace the number of times a work is performed. However, based on a survey of available recordings of these six works, "Third Construction" is by far the most recorded (nearly 16 recordings), suggesting that it is also likely the most performed. "First Construction" and "Second Construction" are typically less "popular" than "Third Construction" and appear on recordings roughly the same number of times, having nine or ten recordings of each. On the other hand, in the "Imaginary Landscape" series, "No. 1" has been recorded the most with seven occurrences, while "No. 2" and "No. 3" are represented by only four recordings each. All of the "Imaginary Landscape" recordings combined do not amount to the number of available "Third Construction" recordings. Perhaps if the title of "Fourth Construction" had been maintained, many more performances and recordings of "Fourth Construction" would exist today.

The use of electronic devices in "Imaginary Landscape No. 2" simply cannot be ignored. This is perhaps the solitary reason that Cage decided to change the title. All five of the compositions that make up the "Imaginary Landscape" series utilize some form of an early electronic instrument. By including apparatuses such as radios, buzzers, amplified coils of wire, test-tone records, and the phonograph, Cage creates unique textures that the three "Constructions" fail to come even close to hinting at. This single yet obvious difference offers the clearest insight into the confusion and potential for inaccuracy when researching this topic.

Even though all six works were composed within four years, there are many similar yet distinct characteristics that set these two series apart. Simply stated, "the 'Constructions' concentrate on intricate rhythmic tactics, modifying dynamics, textures, and timbres for variety along the way. They are, literally, *constructed* from predetermined motives, freeing the composer from aesthetic or expressive choices. Though the 'Imaginary Landscapes' are built upon similar numerical formulas, they can be interpreted as works of fiction, offering evocative, expressive attitudes seldom found in Cage works early or late."[15]

## CONCLUSION

Since the beginning of the twentieth century percussion experimentation, whether it be in a mixed ensemble or with like instruments, has seen tremendous interest and growth. Although the early percussion ensemble can be credited to composers who came before him, it was John Cage who pioneered the first performing ensemble that made consistent and significant appearances. Through this ensemble came commissions, media attention, and a deeper understanding of the future of Cage's musical career. Cage was also able to use this ensemble to feature his compositions and his early theories regarding the creation of music. As a result of these explorations, two remarkable and influential collections of early percussion ensemble music now exist: the "Construction" and "Imaginary Landscape" series.

With this group of six works, Cage supported his philosophies on music by developing important concepts regarding timbre, rhythm, structure, instrumentation, and the adoption of electronic devices into compositions. In retrospect, these can all be seen as significant developments not only in Cage's career, but in the influence these compositions provided for twentieth-century music and beyond. Of this group of works, only "Imaginary Landscape No. 2" stands out as possessing characteristics of both collections. Only through a careful, detailed examination of both the compositional history and specific musical elements contained within it does one realize that this piece is both a "Construction" and an "Imaginary Landscape."

## ENDNOTES

1. Henry Cowell, *Towards New-Primitivism* in *Modern Music* 10/3 (March–April 1933), 153.
2. Leta E. Miller, "The Art of Noise: John Cage, Lou Harrison, and the West Coast Percussion Ensemble, in Perspectives on American Music, 1900–1950," in *Perspectives on American Music, 1900–1950*, ed. Michael Saffle (New York: Garland Publishing, 1993), 217.
3. John Cage, *History of Experimental Music*

*in the United States*, in *Silence* (Middletown, Conn.: Wesleyan University Press, 1961), 71.
4. Leta E. Miller, "Henry Cowell and John Cage: Intersections and Influences, 1933–1941," in *The Journal of the American Musicological Society*, Vol. 59, Number 1, 2006, 63.
5. Henry Cowell, *Letter to John Cage* (New York Public Library Cowell Collection, box 97, March, 23 1937).
6. James Pritchett, *The Music of John Cage* (Cambridge University Press, 1993), 16.
7. *Stuart Smith, "Interview with John Cage," Percussive Notes Research Edition, (March, 1983), 3*.
8. Revill, *The Roaring Silence — John Cage: A Life*, 76.
9. Miller, *The Art of Noise*, 248.
10. David W. Bernstein, "Music I: to the late 1940s," 75.
11. Bernstein, "Music I: to the late 1940s," 76.
12. Gwen Deely, with Jim Theobald, "Oral Defense of Thesis, Hunter Electronic Music Studio, December 20, 1976."
13. Marjory M. Fisher, "Interest Shown in Percussion Music Program," *The San Francisco News*, 8 May, 1942.
14. Alfred Frankenstein, "Music: A Recital on Percussion Instruments," *San Francisco Chronicle* (8 May, 1942), 13.
15. Lange, "Notes on the 'Imaginary Landscape' series."

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